Guided practice

Checking readiness for independent work

Use guided practice when students have seen an explanation but are not yet ready to perform independently. Keep the demand closely aligned with the model and inspect each important decision.

How to do it well

1 Frame the rehearsal. Explain that this is supported practice, not a test. Name the specific feature or step being rehearsed and keep the first burst short.

2 Model and co-work. Show the process briefly, then complete a closely matched example with pupils supplying decisions or steps.

3 Prompt student explanation. Ask pupils to explain why a step is valid, how it connects to the goal, or what would happen if it changed.

4 Use all-in practice. Require every pupil to respond through mini-whiteboards, paired explanation, call and response, a short written step or another visible routine.

5 Give immediate feedback. Name the precise success or misconception, model the correction if needed, and have pupils make the change straight away.

6 Release gradually. Move from teacher model to co-work, prompted attempt, lightly supported attempt and then a small number of independent items.

What this sounds like

“Try only the first decision. Show me which relationship you will use and why. We will check that before moving to the calculation.”

Classroom example. In Languages, the teacher models a sentence and guides a new one with different vocabulary. Everyone writes the first verb choice before the class continues. A mistaken tense is repaired immediately. Students then complete a short independent set, so the handover follows visible success rather than the contribution of a few fluent speakers.

Top tips that make the technique work

Use a separate example. Students should apply the model, rather than reproduce the answer they just watched.

Check one step at a time. A final answer can hide where the reasoning broke down.

Keep everyone active. Brief board responses, written steps or rehearsed explanations make the rehearsal class-wide.

Explain why the step works. Correct performance and understanding of the principle both matter.

Extend guidance when necessary. Independence is the destination, but the release should follow sufficient accuracy rather than elapsed minutes.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Rehearse the target learning with immediate feedback.	Co-working solely with the most confident pupils.
Release responsibility progressively.	Leaving students to practise a common error repeatedly.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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